



Barcelona
2026

Capital Mundial
de l'Arquitectura

PARLOUR GARDENS

DREAMS FROM THE ROOFTOP



TRAVELLING EXHIBITION PROPOSAL

ITINERANCY DOSSIER

PARLOUR GARDENS: DREAMS FROM THE ROOFTOP

AN ITINERARY FOR BOTANICAL GARDENS ACROSS FIVE CLIMATE ZONES

Fifteen ceramic garden models — one original from 1927, fourteen new commissions — travel from Barcelona to partner institutions sharing the same biome. A century of garden thinking, made material.

A LIVING ARCHIVE, LOOKING FOR A HOME

The garden has always travelled. Seeds cross oceans. Species colonise new soils. Ideas, carried in the minds of those who cultivate them, migrate across borders and take root in unexpected places.

In 1926, three artists created something unprecedented in Barcelona: a series of tiny ceramic worlds — jardins de saló, parlour gardens — that compressed the Mediterranean landscape into vessels small enough to rest on a table. Within a year they were in Paris. Within three, in London, Belgium and New York. The garden, made portable, had become a carrier of ideas.

One hundred years later, *Parlour Gardens: Dreams from the Rooftop* revives that impulse — and extends it. After their first presentation at the Barcelona Botanical Garden, these models are ready to travel — and they should travel to you. To gardens that share the same light, the same seasonal rhythms, the same ecological sensibility.

We believe this exhibition belongs in your garden — because the designers who created it were thinking, in part, of gardens exactly like yours.

“TO GIVE THE IMAGINATIVE THE PLEASURES OF THE GARDEN, SOMETHING REAL ON WHICH TO REST THEIR DREAMS, I IMAGINED TINY CERAMIC GARDENS, DECORATED BY RAOUL DUFY AND FIRED BY JOSEP LLORENS ARTIGAS.”

— NICOLAU M. RUBIÓ I TUDURÍ, 1926

ONE CENTURY. FIFTEEN GARDENS. FIVE CLIMATE ZONES.

Parlour Gardens: Dreams from the Rooftop is a large-scale international exhibition selected through open call as a core component of the UNESCO–UIA World Capital of Architecture 2026 programme and fully funded by Barcelona City Council. It is built around a single, precise idea: that the rooftop is the great unrealised landscape of the contemporary city.

Each model has been fabricated in glazed ceramic — combining advanced direct 3D ceramic printing with traditional craft techniques — by ceramicist and designer Martí Baltà and his team at Barcelona 3D Ceramics, and planted with living Mediterranean species curated by horticulture specialist Enric Sancho of Cultidelta.

KEY FACTS	
EXHIBITION	ORIGIN VENUE
Parlour Gardens: Dreams from the Rooftop	Barcelona Botanical Garden, Montjuïc
ORIGIN DATES	PROGRAMME
June – September 2026	UNESCO–UIA World Capital of Architecture 2026
FUNDING (ORIGIN)	MODELS
Barcelona City Council — open call, fully funded	15 ceramic garden models (1 original + 14 new)
STUDIOS	CURATORS
14 teams, 14 countries, 5 homoclimatic regions	Marina Cervera · James Hayter · José Luis Cortés
CERAMICS	PLANTING
Martí Baltà / Barcelona 3D Ceramics	Enric Sancho / Cultidelta

WHY A BOTANICAL GARDEN LIKE YOURS?

The curatorial logic of Parlour Gardens is inseparable from geography. Five zones share the same Mediterranean-type climate — warm, dry summers; mild, wet winters — despite being thousands of miles apart. Each participating studio was matched to the zone that mirrors their home climate; for the itinerary to be true to its own argument, the models should be hosted by botanical gardens that share this same biome.

We are looking for partners in all five climate zones with an active public programme, an interest in contemporary design and landscape practice, and outdoor spaces suited to presenting the models on their pine wood aerial cargo boxes — embracing the déballage aesthetic at the heart of the project.

MEDITERRANEAN BASIN · SPAIN · FRANCE · GREECE · LEBANON · EGYPT · ALGERIA

Target partners — Valencia, Montpellier, Rome, Athens, Istanbul, Tunis, Casablanca, Beirut, Cairo

CALIFORNIA · USA

Target partners — San Francisco Botanical Garden, UC Berkeley, San Diego Botanic Garden, LA Arboretum

CHILE · SOUTH AMERICA

Target partners — Jardín Botánico Nacional, Viña del Mar; botanical collections in Santiago

SOUTH AFRICA — CAPE REGION

Target partners — Kirstenbosch National Botanical Garden, Cape Town

SOUTH-WESTERN AUSTRALIA

Target partners — Kings Park & Botanic Garden Perth, Adelaide Botanic Garden, Royal Botanic Gardens Sydney

The travelling itinerary comprises the fourteen contemporary models, approx. 45 × 45 × 25 cm, 20–40 kg each. The original 1927 piece remains in Barcelona and does not travel.



01 EARTH CHAMBERS
– CORNER



02 ROOTS KNOW
– DOXIADIS



03 MEDINASCAPES
– DOHERTY



04 SKY ISLANDS
– GREENSPAN



05 GOLDRUSH
– HARRIS



06 MISSION MEMORIES
– HOOD



07 EMBEDDED SHIFTS
– KLITZNER



08 ARABESQUES
– LOUAFI



09 JUNKYARD
– MAKHZOUMI/JABR



10 TECTONIC
– MCGREGOR



11 STONE & TREE
– MOLLER



12 DE TOUT TEMPS
– MOSBACH



13 UNDERCOVER HOUSE
– STUTCHBURY

WHAT A PARTNERSHIP LOOKS LIKE

Each model arrives in its pine wood aerial cargo box, which doubles as its display pedestal — the déballage strategy that makes the box part of the presentation. Living planting is cared for by the host institution's horticultural team, following detailed botanical care sheets.

THE HOST RECEIVES

- All models (or curated regional selection) in display-ready cargo boxes
- Full exhibition design package — déballage guidelines, signage, interpretive text
- Introductory video and interpretive panel
- Complete image library, press photography, designer biographies
- Co-branded presence across Parlour Gardens communications
- Curatorial visit and/or round table with participating designers
- First right of refusal on future itinerary dates

THE HOST PROVIDES

- No exhibition fee — curatorial rights and licensing provided free of charge
- All transport costs, plus insurance, for the duration of the hosting period
- Outdoor display space, min. 200 m² for full exhibition
- Full plant maintenance and watering throughout hosting
- Local installation/dismantling coordination (2–3 persons)
- Local marketing and communications using provided assets

The full exhibition may be presented as a single installation or distributed through the garden's homoclimatic zones — the latter strongly preferred, as it recreates the curatorial logic of the original Barcelona presentation. A curated regional selection is available for gardens wishing to present only their own zone's models.

PRACTICALITIES

THE MODELS

NUMBER OF PIECES

14 contemporary models available (1927 piece does not travel)

DIMENSIONS

Approx. 45 × 45 × 25 cm model on wooden transport crate — crate: 78 × 58 × 58 cm plywood pallet-box, Ref. CB867FP

WEIGHT

20–40 kg per model

MATERIAL

Glazed 3D-printed ceramic, living plants and growing medium

OWNERSHIP

Remains with NablaBCN / Parlour Gardens curatorial team

SPACE & LOGISTICS

MINIMUM AREA

200 m² (full) / 60 m² (regional selection)

SURFACE & LIGHT

Flat, stable outdoor/semi-covered; dappled to partial shade

WATER ACCESS

Within 20 m of each model; approx. 2× weekly watering in summer

SECURITY

Overnight access control recommended

TRANSPORT

Aerial cargo, pine wood boxes; costs covered by host institution

CURATORIAL TEAM

Marina Cervera — Project Director, CEO NablaBCN

James Hayter — IFLA Past President, Oxigen

José Luis Cortés — UIA Past President

CRAFT & PRODUCTION

Martí Baltà / Barcelona 3D Ceramics

Enric Sancho / Cultidelta — exhibition plant sponsor

LET'S BEGIN

Expressions of interest are welcome from botanical gardens, public parks and cultural institutions in all five homoclimatic regions worldwide. Please tell us: a brief description of your institution and outdoor spaces, your preferred hosting period, whether you want the full exhibition or a regional selection, and any questions about pieces, logistics or terms.

CONTACT

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Parlour Gardens · NablaBCN

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TRAVELLING TO
BOTANICAL GARDENS WORLDWIDE
FROM OCTOBER 2026